Jonathan García Fuentes

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Development economist and Ph.D. candidate specializing in impact evaluation and the optimization of food security interventions in fragile settings. My research uses machine learning and large-scale RCTs to test program design variations. I have over **10 years** of research and operational experience with a primary focus on quantitative methods. I have led large-scale surveys and targeting exercises in some of the world's largest humanitarian operations, and advised country operations and governments across Nicaragua, Sudan, Mozambique, and the Latin America and Southern Africa regions.

EDUCATION

Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin, Germany October 2026 (expected)
Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) *Supervisors:* Prof. Tilman Brück, Prof. Harald Grethe, and Prof. Andrea Guariso
Visiting Scholar, Cornell College of Human Ecology – Prof. John Hoddinott Fall 2025

Georg-August-Universität Göttingen, Germany
Master's of Science in Development Economics (M.Sc.). *Specialization:* Quantitative Economics.

Università degli Studi di Torino, Italy
Master's in Applied Labour Economics for Development (M.S.)

Universidad Centroamericana (UCA), Nicaragua
Bachelor of Science in Applied Economics (B.Sc.). *Minor:* Economic & Territorial Development.

EMPLOYMENT

Zero Hunger Lab (Humboldt University of Berlin & IGZ) **July 2023 – present**
Research Fellow: Economic Development and Food Security Research Group - IGZ
Research Projects:

- Impact Evaluation (cRCT): Community-based vs. data-driven targeting — Experimental evidence from the DRC. *Collaboration with WFP-Office of Evaluation (OEV) and WB's DIME.* **REPORT**
- Beneficiaries' preferences for food assistance in DRC and Afghanistan. *Collaboration with WFP-OEV.* **PAPER 1** **PAPER 2**
- Horticulture Policy and Food Security (Systematic Review). **DRAFT**
- Impact Evaluation Targeting Acute Malnutrition in Cox Baxar. Design phase.

International Security and Development Center (ISDC) **November 2023 – present**
Research Affiliate: Welfare Program
Research Projects:

- Impact Evaluation (RCT): Targeting Humanitarian Aid in Crisis — Evidence from the reduction of WFP Assistance in Lebanon. *Collaboration with WFP-OEV and WFP-CO Lebanon.* **REPORT**

Collaboration for International Development Economics Research (Cornell University) **May 2025 – present**
Research Fellow: STARS Program

United Nations World Institute for Development Economics Research (UNU-WIDER) **April – June 2025**
Research (PhD) Fellow: Project: Optimizing Transfer Value in DRC — Household and Community Impact. **DRAFT**

United Nations World Food Programme (WFP) **October 2020 – July 2023**
Regional Bureau for Southern Africa | *Regional Targeting & Research Officer* June 2021 – June 2023

- Targeting and Assessment Advisor for **12 countries** (including DRC, Mozambique, Madagascar, Malawi, Zimbabwe, Lesotho, Tanzania, Angola), to reach **17 million** beneficiaries in the region.
- Led a **USD$100,000** innovation grant for an AI model for drought prediction (precipitation, soil moisture, basin levels) for Anticipatory Action in Mozambique and Zimbabwe (*with ESA and Oxford Earth Observation, OxEO*).
- WFP lead for the training and development of AI models for flood impact prediction during the 2022 KwaZulu-Natal floods in South Africa (*with the WFP Innovation Accelerator and Google Accelerator*).
- Led a multi-country impact evaluation (**Rapid Rural Transformation**) in Madagascar, Mozambique, and DRC.
- Co-led the Regional Urban Preparedness (**RUP**) project, a **€1.3 million** ECHO-funded initiative.

Cabo Delgado, Mozambique | *Vulnerability-Based Targeting Coordinator* August – November 2021

- Designed and coordinated the first population registry and targeting system for **1.6 million** IDPs and host families.

Sudan | *Profiling, Targeting & Studies Coordinator* October 2020 – June 2021

- Designed and implemented assessments and targeting systems for WFP's **6 million** people operation.

Leibniz Universität Hannover & German Institute for Economic Research (DIW) **June – October 2020**
Research Assistant: RCT - "Financial Education, Mobile Money, and Small-scale Entrepreneurs in Uganda."

Centre for Modern Indian Studies (CeMIS) **January 2019 – September 2020**
Research Assistant to Prof. Sebastian Vollmer: RCTs, quasi-experiments, and descriptive studies.
UNICEF-commissioned research on adolescent and maternal pregnancy and childhood diseases in West & Central Africa. *Co-author:* **PAPER 1**, **PAPER 2**; *Research Assistant:* **PAPER 3**, **PAPER 4**.
Field Coordinator: Impact evaluation of a new general hospital. N=12,000 patient exit survey.

United Nations World Food Programme (WFP) **April 2014 – September 2018**
Mozambique | *RAM Officer* December 2016 - June 2017
– Designed and implemented a monitoring system for a **1 million** beneficiary emergency operation and led WFP's contribution to the first National Nutrition Survey (**3,000 households**) and IPC Acute Malnutrition.
Regional Bureau for Latin America | *RAM Officer* April – December 2016
– Market assessments and price monitoring advisor; Data manager post-earthquake food security assessment in Ecuador.
Nicaragua | *Research, Assessment, and Monitoring (RAM) Associate* April 2014 – September 2018
– Supported monitoring, market and impact assessments, and price monitoring for WFP's operation in Nicaragua.

Consultants for Development S.A. (COPADES) **November 2012 - December 2013**
Junior Economist: advised on the 2012 base-year input–output matrix (Nicaragua's Central Bank), the 2012 tax reform (National Council of Private Enterprise), and the 2013 social security reform (National Institute of Pensions and Social Security).

NITLAPAN | *Research Assistant* **September – November 2012**
TECHO | *Data & Analysis Coordinator: Census of Slums in the Pacific of Nicaragua* **REPORT** **January – November 2012**

RESEARCH

PhD Dissertation: *Optimizing Food Security Interventions in Fragile Settings*

- Targeting Humanitarian Food Assistance: A Field Experiment in Eastern DRC. *Joint work with Felipe A. Dunsch, Andrea Guariso, Marcus Holmlund, and Kristen McCollum.* **DRAFT** **BLOG** **MEDIA**
- Optimizing Transfer Value in Humanitarian Food Assistance: Welfare and Community Impacts from the DRC. *Joint work with Aysha Twose.* **DRAFT**
- When Humanitarian Assistance Fades: Experimental Evidence from a Nationwide Program in Lebanon. *Joint work with Ghassan Baliki, Micah Cruz, Felipe A. Dunsch, Andrea Guariso, Jonas Heirman, and Dorothee Weiffen.* **DRAFT**
- Targeting Against Shocks: Data, Experts, or Impact-based Targeting in Lebanon. *Joint work with Ghassan Baliki, Micah Cruz, Felipe A. Dunsch, Andrea Guariso, Jonas Heirman, and Dorothee Weiffen.* **DRAFT**
- Aid Preferences Among Subsistence Farmers in the DRC. *Joint work with Felipe A. Dunsch, Jonas Heirman, and Jennifer Waidler.* **DRAFT**
- Beneficiaries' Preferences for the Design and Targeting of Humanitarian Food Assistance: Evidence from DRC and Afghanistan. *Joint work with Felipe A. Dunsch, Andrea Guariso, and Heng Zhu.* **DRAFT**

Work in Progress

- Targeting Food Insecurity at a High Frequency.
- AI versus Communities versus Experts Targeting of Food Assistance.
- Social Protection as Insurance for Conflict.

Pre-PhD Research

- The Impacts of a New General Hospital on Waiting Time and Out-of-Pocket Expenditure for Outpatient Care. **DRAFT**
- Predictors of patients' choice and pathways of access to hospitals under universal health coverage: a case study of the Nicaraguan capital. *BMC Health Services Research* 2021. **10.1186/s12913-021-07333-z**
- Socio-economic predictors of adolescent marriage and maternity in West and Central Africa between 1986 and 2017. *J Glob Health* 2021. **10.7189/jogh.11.13002**
- Levels and trends of adolescent marriage and maternity in West and Central Africa, 1986-2017. *J Glob Health* 2021. **10.7189/jogh.11.13001**
- The Gender Pay Gap: Triple penalty? Woman, mother, and informal. Evidence from Nicaragua. *Revista de Economía y Finanzas*, Vol. 8. Central Bank of Nicaragua. **PDF Spanish** **Original (English)** **Code** **Best Paper 2020**

FELLOWSHIPS, SCHOLARSHIPS & AWARDS

- Joachim Herz Add-on Fellowship for Interdisciplinary Economics. €12,500 2024-2026
- WFP's Innovation Award for developing a drought forecast model for Southern Africa. US$100,000 2021
- Economy, Finance, and Development Award. 1st place, research award. Nicaragua's Central Bank. US$4,000 2020
- DAAD-EPOS Programme Scholarship for Graduate Studies in Development Economics. €35,000. 2018
- MALED Scholarship for Graduate Studies in Labour Economics by ILO and University of Turin. €7,000. 2017
- Academic Excellence Award, Universidad Centroamericana, Applied Economics. 2013. 2013
- Young Researchers, Universidad Centroamericana - Nicaragua. 3rd place. 2012
- Scholarship for Undergraduate Studies in Applied Economics, 2009-2013. Universidad Centroamericana. 2009
- Bronze medallist with Nicaragua's national basketball team (U15 and U17), Central American Championship. 2007

TEACHING

Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin - Germany July 2023 - present

- *Teaching Assistant (Graduate):* • Economics of Rural Development

Georg-August-Universität Göttingen - Germany January 2019 – September 2020

- *Teaching Assistant (Graduate):* • Development Economics III • Poverty & inequality

Universidad Centroamericana (UCA) - Nicaragua February 2010 – December 2013

- *Lecturer (Undergraduate):* • Macroeconomic Accounts • Business Economics.
- *Teaching Assistant (Graduate):* • Econometrics I and Statistical Inference.• Mathematics I, II and III.

CONFERENCES, LECTURES & INVITED TALKS

2026: CSAE (*Oxford*); German Development Economics Conference; EDEG (*Kiel*); Fragile Lives (*Berlin*).
2025: WIDER Conference (*UNU-WIDER*); CSAE (*Oxford*); LEADS (Bremen).
2024: Leibniz Research Network CrisEn (Berlin); German Economic Association (VfS).
Panelist: Forgotten Conflicts, jointly with Prof. Martin Gassebner and Prof. Anna Minasyan (*U. of Göttingen*); Food Security and Conflicts, with Johan Swinnen, Lukas Kornher, and Bettina Rudlof. IAMO Forum (*Halle*).
2023: *Panelist:* Are we on track for Zero Hunger? with Prof. Meike Wollni and Margherita Squarcina (*U of Göttingen*); *Invited lecture:* Poverty and food insecurity measurement and targeting (*Technische Universität München*).
2022–2019: *Panelist:* Evidence and evaluation in humanitarian contexts (*SAMEA, Johannesburg*); *Invited lecturer:* Targeting the ultra-poor; Measuring food insecurity (*Technische Universität München*); DAAD annual meeting (*Universität Hamburg*).

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Software & Programming

Stats./GIS/Data Vis.: STATA, R, Python, Ngene, Gi, ArcGIS, TABLEAU.
AI/LLMs: Claude, Codex.
Survey: ODK, SurveyCTO.
Text: LaTeX, M. Office.

Languages

Native: Spanish.
Fluent: English, Portuguese, and Italian.
Intermediate: German (B1) and French (B1).